

Vanbrugh

Architect, soldier, playwright and politician John Vanbrugh (1664–1726) was, with Hawksmoor, the leading exponent of the English Baroque style, demonstrating it abundantly in two colossal palaces. The first, Castle Howard in Yorkshire (opposite, 1702–12), won him instant acclaim as well as his next commission, Blenheim Palace in Oxfordshire (1705–22). He later designed Seaton Delaval, Northumberland (1718–28).

Though still untrained when he took on Castle Howard, Vanbrugh had an inherent grasp of architecture, particularly in creating a sense of grandeur and drama, and many of his buildings incorporate elements from castles, such as battlements and towers. He also blended medieval and classical forms with traditional English ideas. It is possible that he was influenced by the French Baroque style while imprisoned in France for espionage (1688–93). All his buildings were collaborations with Hawksmoor, who provided the practicality that Vanbrugh needed to realize his ambitious designs.

